Was Rakhsh More Than a Horse?

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Hi! It’s been a while! The last few weeks have been so busy with school, playdates, birthdays, and today I played in our county chess tournament and won a medal! WOOHOO!!!



In my last post, I tried to figure out if Rostam and Percy Jackson would be friends. I decided YES, but there was one part of the story I kept thinking about after I finished writing it: Rakhsh!

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So to recap... Percy is the son of Poseidon, who is the god of the sea and horses. That means Percy can actually talk to horses. So if Percy ever time-traveled to the *Shahnameh*, he could talk to Rakhsh! I said that Rakhsh has probably been waiting a thousand years for someone to hear his side of the story. But then I started thinking maybe I should listen to his side too. Because Rakhsh is technically Rostam's horse, but is he really *just* a horse?

Spoiler: I don't think so.

How Rostam Got Rakhsh

When Rostam was old enough to choose a horse, his father Zal had horses brought from all over. But there was a problem. Rostam was SO strong that when he pressed his hand down on their backs, they couldn't hold his weight! Then Rostam saw Rakhsh, a powerful young horse who was said to have the strength of an elephant. Rostam threw his lasso around him and tried to take him, but Rakhsh belonged to a herd, so Rostam asked how much he cost.

The answer is one of my favorite lines in the *Shahnameh*. The herdsman basically tells Rostam, *"The price of Rakhsh is Iran. Go save it."* That's a pretty big price for a horse! But I also think it says something important about Rakhsh. Rostam and Rakhsh were never supposed to just ride around for fun. From the very beginning, they were going to protect Iran together. And that's exactly what they did!

Lightning and Radiance

Rakhsh's name means "lightning" or "radiance" in Persian, and I think both meanings make sense! Lightning makes sense because Rakhsh is

so fast and powerful. He carries Rostam across deserts, through battles, and on journeys that other horses probably couldn't survive.

But I actually like "radiance" even more. In the *Shahnameh*, Rakhsh is described as bright and dappled, like red rose petals scattered on a golden background, so he literally looked radiant. I think the name fits him in another way too. Rostam has to deal with wars, monsters, betrayals, and some other really sad things. Through all of it, Rakhsh is there with him. I'd say that's pretty radiant!

Rakhsh Was a Warrior Too

Everybody remembers Rostam's Seven Trials. He fights a lion, a desert (yes, basically an entire desert!), a dragon, a witch, a warrior, Divs, and finally the biggest Div of all…the terrifying White Div. Except if you really think about it, in his first trial, Rostam didn't actually fight the lion… Rakhsh did!

So in the first trial, Rostam is sleeping when a lion comes to attack him. Rakhsh could have just woken Rostam up and let the greatest hero of Persia fight off the lion. Instead, Rakhsh fights the lion himself and actually kills it with his teeth and hooves! But then Rostam got mad at Rakhsh for not waking him up.

So then came the dragon. AGAIN, Rostam is sleeping and Rakhsh sees a dragon coming toward them. Now Rakhsh does what Rostam told him to do and wakes him up. But the dragon disappears before Rostam can see it, so Rostam goes back to sleep.

The dragon comes back and Rakhsh wakes Rostam again, but the dragon disappears AGAIN. This time Rostam gets SO mad at Rakhsh! Poor Rakhsh. He's literally trying to save Rostam's life and getting yelled at for it. But do you want to hear the important part? Rakhsh still tries to do the right thing. When the dragon comes back a THIRD time,

Rakhsh wakes Rostam again. Finally, Rostam sees the dragon, and Rostam and Rakhsh defeat it together.

I think that says a lot about Rakhsh. Rostam gets mad at Rakhsh for waking him up, but Rakhsh doesn't care. He knows Rostam is in danger, so he keeps trying anyway. And if Rakhsh had just given up and gone back to sleep too, who knows what would have happened to Rostam!

Rakhsh Was Always There for Rostam

The more I read about Rakhsh, the more I think Rostam couldn't have become the greatest hero in the *Shahnameh* without him. Rakhsh carried him across Iran and into battles. He crossed the terrible desert with him during the Seven Trials. He fought beside him, warned him about danger, and protected Rostam when he slept. Rostam is the hero in the *Shahnameh* that everyone knows about, but Rakhsh was basically his secret weapon.

And even though Rostam sometimes got annoyed with Rakhsh, he still really loved him. In my post about what makes a hero truly epic, I wrote about the time a stable boy accidentally let Rakhsh wander away. The boy was terrified Rostam would punish him, but Rostam realized it was an honest mistake and forgave him. Rakhsh wasn't just a horse to Rostam. He was family.

At the very end of Rostam's life, Rostam and Rakhsh fall into the evil trap set by Rostam's half-brother Shaghad… and they die together. It's such a sad and unfair way for them to die. But Rakhsh was still there with him. He was there for Rostam's adventures from the beginning, and he was by his side at the very end.

That doesn't sound like a hero and his horse to me. It sounds like two pretty cool heroes.

So… Was Rakhsh More Than a Horse?

Definitely! Rostam is the greatest hero in the *Shahnameh*, but even the greatest heroes need someone looking out for them. For Rostam, that was Rakhsh.

I think that's why I love Rakhsh so much. He doesn't get much attention from anyone but Rostam. Nobody sends for Rakhsh when Iran is in danger. They always send for Rostam. But wherever Rostam goes, Rakhsh does too. He's always helping Rostam protect Iran.

So if Percy Jackson ever travels back to the *Shahnameh*, I still hope he talks to Rakhsh first. I bet Rakhsh would have a LOT to say about Rostam… and I want to hear all of it!

What do you think? Was Rakhsh a horse, a sidekick, a friend, or an actual hero?

Thanks for reading. See you next time!

Jack

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